Harrovian Kashmiri Brahmin patrician Jawaharlal Nehru and the outcaste-born Maharashtrian Bhimrao Ambedkar, the first ever ‘untouchable’ to gain a university education. Both men found themselves increasingly at odds with M. K. Gandhi’s vision of a *Ramrajya*, a model of government which harked back to a golden age as celebrated in the *Ramayana* when Lord Rama returns from exile to rule over Ayodhya.

For the Mahatma, the ideal national flag of an independent India was that which had emerged from the meeting of the All India National Congress at Vijayawada in what is now Andhra Pradesh in 1921, when a local activist from Machilipatnam, an ex-soldier turned geologist named Pingali Venkayya, produced a design that showed a *charka* or spinning-wheel superimposed upon two horizontal bands of red and green, Hindus and Muslims respectively – modified by Gandhi with the addition of a white stripe in the middle signifying purity. This tricolour and *charka* was adopted as the official flag of the National Congress in 1931 but came to be seen as having communal undertones. In July 1947, with Independence fast approaching, a new design was hurriedly agreed upon without Gandhi’s approval, in which the *charka* was replaced by a *chakra*, representing dharma and the moral law as promulgated by Ashoka Maurya centuries earlier.

In the event, the Mahatma’s tragic murder at the hands of a religious bigot on 30 January 1948 ended all talk of *Ramrajya* in Government circles. However, in the years that followed the distinction between history and politics began to blur as Prime Minister Nehru and the Congress Party embarked on a nation-building project with the entirely laudable aim of creating a stronger sense of national unity.

They did this in part by building up the Freedom Struggle into a quasi-sacred national epic to rival the *Mahabharata* and the *Ramayana*. Every new nation from ancient Rome through to the United States of America has drawn strength